



like Roboto Slab.

- Bracketed (curved-transition) serifs, not mechanical slab serifs.
- Lowercase **g** is single-story (a simple open descender loop) — rules out Garamond, Baskerville, Palatino, which use double-story g's.

- Lowercase **y** has a curved, hooked descender rather than a straight diagonal one.
- Double-story **a**, straight-leg **R**, plain-footed **L** — sturdy, screen-native proportions rather than classical book-typography proportions.

Taken together, this reads as a **humanist, screen-optimized book-serif** — the family of faces built to sit comfortably next to a humanist sans like Open Sans, rather than a European classical-revival serif. That matches your account exactly: your sister was looking for "a font like Open Sans, but serif."

WORKING HYPOTHESIS — NEEDS CONFIRMATION

The strongest match by letterform is **Noto Serif** (formerly Droid Serif) or a close relative such as **PT Serif** or **Source Serif**. This isn't a guess pulled from thin air: Noto Serif was built as the deliberate serif sibling to Droid Sans, by the same type studio and design lineage (Ascender/Monotype, the studio behind Open Sans itself) in the same era — it is *the* canonical "Open Sans, but serif" answer, and its letterform DNA (single-story g, curved y, moderate contrast, bracketed serifs) lines up with the logo. PT Serif is the next-closest candidate for the same reason — designed as a companion to a humanist sans, similarly screen-native.

FLAGGED, NOT ASSUMED

I can't verify this from a rendered logo file with certainty — there's no font-matching tool in this environment, and a hand-vectorized wordmark can drift from its source typeface in ways that are hard to detect visually (tightened spacing, adjusted terminals, a custom ligature between "R" and the star mark). Before this becomes a locked design-system token, resolve it one of two ways: (1) ask your sister which font she matched it to when the sign was made — she may still have the file or the name — or (2) run the logo art through a proper font-identification tool (WhatTheFont, Fontspring Matcherator) using a clean vector or high-res crop of just the wordmark. Until then, treat "**a Noto Serif / PT Serif-class humanist book-serif**" as the working direction for display type across every territory below, not a final answer.

One more note: the logo itself resolves the color question with certainty. The navy and gold in public/full-logo.webp are the anchors — every territory below treats them as fixed and only proposes how to extend, deploy, and support them.

Deliberately not limited to law-firm websites — the sharpest lessons for this brief come from adjacent fields that solved the same underlying problem: making dense professional credibility scannable without flattening it.

LITIGATION BOUTIQUE

Susman Godfrey

A trial-only litigation firm whose site leads with plain declarative confidence ("Choose Exceptional") rather than aggressive imagery or macho language. **Principle:** formidability is communicated through restraint and directness, not gavels, courtroom drama, or tough-guy copy — directly relevant to expressing "beat the opposing side" without sounding like marketing bravado.

ARCHITECTURE PRACTICE PORTFOLIOS

David Chipperfield Architects / Herzog & de Meuron-style sites

Restrained grid, generous margins, minimal ornamentation — the work itself (not decoration) carries the authority. **Principle:** a "project-as-evidence" pattern — each commission presented factually, with specifics — maps directly onto treating each matter or client relationship as a discrete, citable proof point rather than marketing copy.

CONSULTING INSIGHT ARTICLES

McKinsey / BCG-style long-form Insights pages

Dense professional analysis made scannable through numbered findings, pull-quotes, and a persistent section rail. **Principle:** the exact pattern needed for About's Training history and Positions record — a summary a skimmer can absorb in five seconds, with the full analytical depth available without leaving the page.

LEGAL CITATION & CASE-ARCHIVE UX

Court-opinion archive conventions (e.g., Oyez-style case treatment)

Case citations are typeset as their own object — distinct rhythm, distinct weight — never buried mid-sentence. **Principle:** Russ's nine reported appellate decisions deserve this exact treatment; right now they're flattened into paragraph text and lose all their weight.

INDEPENDENT PROFESSIONAL PRACTICE**Boutique medical & financial-advisory practice sites**

Sites built around one named practitioner that balance a real portrait and plain-language bio with credentials available on demand rather than dumped up front.

Principle: the "trusted long-term adviser" register this project needs — warm without becoming a lifestyle brand, credentialed without becoming a résumé.

DATA-LED JOURNALISM PROFILES**Bloomberg Businessweek / ProPublica-style profile long-reads**

Narrative prose interleaved with embedded stat call-outs and small data visualizations.

Principle: a 90% trial win rate or a 150,000-participant training history reads as evidence, not adjective, when it's set apart typographically instead of written as a sentence fragment.

2026 LEGAL-MARKETING TREND DATA**Industry-wide movement (see sources below)**

Current legal-sector design writing independently converges on: serif-for-heading / sans-for-body "modern authority" pairings, editorial layout thinking over corporate-brochure thinking, and commissioned photography of real people replacing stock imagery. **Relevance:** this confirms the direction below is aligned with a real, current shift — not chasing novelty for its own sake — and that navy-plus-warm-accent palettes are actively recurring in the category rather than reading as automatically dated.

PLAIN-SPOKEN LONG-FORM WRITING**Independent editorial sites built around one voice**

Sites organized as a single author's ongoing body of work — plain sentences, real specificity, no forced friendliness. **Principle:** "Call me Russ" is best expressed in sentence-level word choice and address ("you," direct statements), not in illustration style or rounded UI chrome.

TERRITORY A

1.   

2. A curated professional record where every claim site

The Record

01 CORE IDEA

The site is organized like a well-kept case file: specific, dated, citable. Every practice area and every credential is written and laid out as a claim backed immediately by evidence — a case citation, a client category, a number, a matter type — rather than as prose that asserts competence in the abstract. Nothing is hidden to look minimal; instead, depth is organized so the reader always knows where they are and what's been proven so far.

02 BRAND FIT

This territory earns trust and litigation strength almost automatically — nine cited appellate decisions and a 90% trial record, laid out as citable fact, are inherently formidable without a single aggressive word. The risk is on the other side of the tension: evidence-forward design can read clinical if the connective language (section intros, the About opening, Contact copy) isn't deliberately written in Russ's plain, direct voice. This territory needs its warmth imported through word choice and portraiture — it won't arrive from the layout alone.

03 VISUAL VOCABULARY

A disciplined column grid with a consistent left-hand rail for wayfinding (section labels, not decoration). Generous but not luxurious spacing — enough room for citations and stat call-outs to breathe, not so much that density reads as emptiness. Thin structural rules instead of shadowed cards; borders used sparingly to separate evidence blocks from narrative prose. Numbering is used only where it's real — reported decisions in chronological sequence, representative matters in a real list — never as decoration. Section transitions are simple horizontal-rule breaks, not scroll animation. Motion is minimal: a brief, single fade/slide on progressive-disclosure reveals, nothing ambient or looping.

04 COLOR SYSTEM

☐ Navy — structure & headings #1E275E

☐ Gold — evidence markers only #FDB613

☐ Paper #FBFAF6

☐ Sunk panel #EFFFF7

☐ Body text #3F4A63

Citation ink (dark gold, text-safe) **#7A6A3A**

Navy carries structure — headings, rules, the persistent section rail — so it reads as institutional backbone rather than decoration. Gold is demoted from "brand color used everywhere" to **evidence signal**: it marks the specific element that is proof (a citation number, a stat call-out border, a "verified credential" tick) and appears nowhere else, which makes it mean something every time it shows up instead of decorating buttons at random. A warm off-white paper (not stark white, not cream) keeps long reading sessions comfortable. Dark surface uses a near-black navy-tinted ground with gold brightened for legibility. Because gold is reserved for small, high-value marks rather than large fills, contrast against paper/ink stays comfortably within WCAG AA even at the brighter tone.

05 TYPOGRAPHY

The office-sign serif (working hypothesis: Noto Serif / PT Serif-class) is used exclusively for headings, section labels, and the pull-quoted proof statements — never for body paragraphs, where its weight would slow reading over 800-word sections. Body copy pairs it with a humanist sans in the Open Sans family (Open Sans itself, or a close, more refined relative like Source Sans 3 or Inter, chosen for x-height and number legibility) at a genuine responsive type scale — not the current fixed 16px. Citations get their own small treatment: a monospace or tabular-figure numeral set, hung left, distinct from surrounding prose, echoing how legal citation format actually looks. Reading width is capped near 68–72 characters regardless of container width. Navigation, labels, and tags stay in the sans face at a small, tracked-out size to visually separate "structure" from "content."

06 IMAGERY & ART DIRECTION

Minimal reliance on hero photography — this territory can function well with little to no new photography, which is a real practical advantage. Where imagery appears, it should be documentary and specific: a real desk, a real filing shelf, a real view from the Palm Avenue office, Russ mid-conversation rather than posed. No gavels, no columns, no stock handshake, no skyline. If budget allows one commissioned shoot, it should prioritize a strong environmental portrait of Russ over any generic office photography.

07 HOME-PAGE EXPRESSION

HERO — plain statement of who the firm serves + one hard number (not a photo)

PROOF STRIP — 3–4 credential marks inline (AV Preeminent · Super Lawyer · 90% trial record)

FIRM INTRO — one tight paragraph, Russ's voice, plain language, no boilerplate

PRACTICE MAP — six areas, each with one differentiator line, not just a label — link to each

RECORD PREVIEW — 2–3 citable proof points pulled from About (a case, a client category)

RUSS — short human intro + portrait, "Call me Russ" in his own words, link to contact

CONSULT — the existing form, framed with one sentence of expectation-setting

FOOTER UTIL — Payment access lives here as a clear, calm secondary action, not a link to a page

08 EXPERTISE-PAGE EXPRESSION

Each practice area becomes a short standalone section (not a single-paragraph tab panel): a plain-language description of the kinds of problems it covers, a short list of representative matter types, and — critically — one proof point pulled directly from About (a case citation, a client name where nameable, a number) with a direct link into the relevant About section. Long-page scroll with anchor navigation on desktop; the same anchors collapse into a compact jump-menu on mobile rather than a hidden accordion. Deep-linkable by topic, exactly as today, but every topic now visibly connects forward to evidence instead of dead-ending.

09 ABOUT-PAGE EXPRESSION

Structured as record, not résumé. Opens with a concise, human biography (3–4 sentences, plain language) and a portrait — immediately followed by an unconditional "top credentials" strip: AV Preeminent, Super Lawyer, 90% trial record, nine reported decisions, admissions summary — visible without any interaction. Below that, distinct, differently-patterned sections for Trial & Appellate Record (citation-styled list), Training & Speaking (grouped by relationship, headline number first), Positions (a real timeline, not a bullet list), Admissions (compact reference table), Ratings (badges with one-line context), and Clients (grouped by sector — health care & nonprofit first, matching the site's stated audience priority — not alphabetical). A sticky section rail (not a tab system) lets the page behave like one long, well-organized document rather than a set of hidden drawers; someone can genuinely read the whole thing, or jump straight to what they need.

10 CONTACT-PAGE EXPRESSION

Retains the dual-path structure (form + direct phone/email + map) but adds what's currently missing: one short, plain-language paragraph up top setting expectations — what happens after submission, and a clear, non-alarming statement that filling out the form doesn't itself create an attorney-client relationship (final wording pending Russ/legal review). The tone stays conversational, not templated legal boilerplate, consistent with "comfortable to confide in."

11 PAYMENT-PAGE EXPRESSION

The compact page stays, but earns its space: a short reassurance line before the button ("You'll be securely redirected to LawPay, our payment processor — here's what to expect"), a visible security cue, and a plain "questions about your bill? Call or email us" fallback right next to the button rather than requiring a detour to Contact. A small persistent "Make a Payment" link in the header/footer utility area supplements — never replaces — the full route, so a returning client typing the URL from memory or a bookmark still lands on a complete, self-sufficient page.

12 RESPONSIVE BEHAVIOR

Desktop: sticky section rail beside long-form content, generous 68–72ch reading column. Tall tablet (1024×1366): the rail can stay if width allows, or collapse to a horizontal sticky tab strip at the top of the content — either way, dense About content gets real, tuned treatment at this width instead of inheriting the desktop layout wholesale, unlike today's site. Mobile: section rail becomes a compact "jump to" dropdown pinned just below the page header; content flows as one long scroll beneath it — no hidden panels, no empty first-load state, since everything is visible by default and merely reachable faster via the jump menu.

13 RISKS

- Reads too much like a report or a legal memo if the connective prose isn't deliberately warmed with Russ's actual voice — the single biggest execution risk.
- Citation-styled treatment for case references could feel over-formal if applied too heavily outside the Litigation/Appellate sections.
- Requires real editorial discipline to maintain — every new credential or matter needs to be

requires real editorial discipline to maintain. Every new credential or matter needs to be written with a proof point, not just added to a list, or the pattern erodes over time.

- Lower dependence on new photography is an advantage for cost, but also a risk: without at least one strong environmental portrait of Russ, the "comfortable to talk to" half of the brand tension has nothing to land on visually.

TERRITORY B

Open Door

Russ is the interface. The site reads like sitting across the desk from him.

01 CORE IDEA

The site speaks in first person, addresses the visitor directly as "you," and treats every page as an extension of an actual conversation with Russ. Credentials exist, but they're introduced the way Russ himself would bring them up — in passing, in service of a point, not as a résumé dump. Portraiture and plain language do more work than structure or data visualization.

02 BRAND FIT

This is the most direct translation of "Call me Russ" — informal address, empathetic framing, a real sense of an ongoing adviser relationship rather than a one-time transaction. It's the strongest territory for approachability and for long-term-client warmth. It's the weakest territory for the "formidable" half of the tension: a sophisticated health-system general counsel or a referring attorney evaluating local counsel is looking for institutional rigor first, and a warmth-led register risks under-signaling that rigor unless the trial record is given real, undiluted visual weight somewhere prominent.

03 VISUAL VOCABULARY

Looser, more asymmetric composition — text blocks sized and placed the way a letter or a long email might be, not a rigid grid. Wider use of a strong portrait or two as structural

anchors rather than pure typography. Soft dividers instead of hard rules; sections separated by generous breathing room rather than boxed panels. Interaction character is calm and conversational: gentle reveal-on-scroll for narrative sections, no data-visualization motifs. Cards are avoided in favor of long, readable blocks — this territory should feel like reading, not browsing a directory.

04 COLOR SYSTEM

- ☐ Navy — used sparingly, for Russ's voice/quotes **#1E275E**
- ☐ Gold — warmth accent, underlines, highlights **#FDB613**
- ☐ Warm paper **#FAF6EE**
- ☐ Warm neutral panel **#E7E0CF**
- ☐ Body text (warm charcoal) **#4A4235**

Navy recedes from "everywhere" to "Russ's own voice" — used behind pull-quotes attributed directly to him, so it reads as a person speaking, not corporate chrome. Gold becomes a genuine warmth device: soft underlines on links, a highlight behind key phrases, the accent on the portrait framing — doing real emotional work rather than sitting on one button. The neutral palette shifts warmer than Territory A's — closer to paper and parchment than off-white — which suits a conversational register but needs care: pushed too far, it drifts toward the "cozy cream + serif" look that reads as a generic wellness or coaching site rather than a law practice, so warmth should stay restrained and paired with crisp, confident type rather than soft illustration.

05 TYPOGRAPHY

The office-sign serif is used more expansively here — not just headings but occasional larger-scale pull-quotes in Russ's own words, treated almost like a letter's signature line. Body text stays in a humanist sans for everyday reading, but line length runs slightly shorter (55–65 characters) to reinforce the "personal letter" feeling rather than a "report" feeling. Stats and credentials are set in-line with the prose rather than pulled into separate data blocks — consistent with how Russ would actually mention them in conversation, not itemized like a spec sheet.

06 IMAGERY & ART DIRECTION

This territory is the most photography-dependent of the three, and honestly, so. It needs at least one genuinely strong, warm, unposed portrait of Russ — ideally several, showing

him in conversation, at his desk, maybe in the Central Valley setting that's part of the firm's identity. Stock photography of any kind would be actively damaging here, since the entire premise rests on authenticity. If a real photography budget and session aren't feasible in the near term, this territory is hard to execute credibly and should be deprioritized until they are.

07 HOME-PAGE EXPRESSION

OPENING — Russ's portrait + a first-person opening line in his voice, not a slogan
WHO I HELP — plain paragraph naming the audiences directly, second person ("if you")
HOW I WORK — practical, solution-oriented framing — creativity + trust, in his words
WHAT I'VE DONE — a few concrete results woven into short narrative, not a stat graphic
PRACTICE AREAS — simple list, plainly described, invites a click rather than sell
LET'S TALK — consultation form framed as an invitation, warm copy
PAYMENT — quiet footer link, no separate visual emphasis

08 EXPERTISE-PAGE EXPRESSION

Framed less as a service catalog and more as "here's what I actually spend my time on and why it matters to you" — short, first-person paragraphs per area, occasionally referencing a client story in general terms. Weaker at rapid self-qualification for a visitor comparing several firms quickly (a B2B buyer skimming for keywords may find this slower to parse), which is this territory's clearest structural cost relative to Territory A.

09 ABOUT-PAGE EXPRESSION

Leads hard with narrative — a real, well-written biography section that reads like a story, not a form. Credentials appear woven into that story ("the same year I made partner, I argued my first case before the Ninth Circuit...") with a clearly-labeled "see my full credentials" reference section below for the reader who wants the itemized record. This is the territory's biggest risk area: the 800-word Training history, the 29-name client list, and the 6-court admissions record are all inherently archival, list-shaped content that resists narrative treatment — they'll likely need to break out of this territory's voice into a more neutral reference format for that portion of the page, which creates a visible seam in the design language.

10 CONTACT-PAGE EXPRESSION

This territory's strongest page. Expectation-setting and confidentiality language sit naturally here, written as Russ reassuring a nervous first-time caller rather than as legal boilerplate — "you can tell me what's going on, and we'll figure out together whether I'm the right person to help." Feels safe and human by construction, not by add-on copy.

11 PAYMENT-PAGE EXPRESSION

Kept simple and warm — a short, human line ("thanks for trusting us with this — here's how to take care of it") rather than a security-forward, transactional tone. Works well for existing clients who already have the relationship; slightly weaker at building fresh confidence for a first-time payer who hasn't yet formed that relationship, since the reassurance here leans on rapport rather than visible security signaling.

12 RESPONSIVE BEHAVIOR

Because this territory avoids rigid grids, it collapses naturally to mobile — long readable blocks were already close to a mobile reading pattern. The risk is the opposite: on wide desktop, loosely-composed text can feel under-designed or sparse unless portrait imagery and pull-quotes are used deliberately to anchor the width. Dense About content remains the hard case at every width, per above.

13 RISKS

- Highest risk of reading as "too soft" for institutional B2B evaluators — health systems and referring attorneys vetting counsel may want to see rigor before rapport.
- Entirely dependent on a real, well-produced photography session — without it, this territory has no visual foundation to stand on.
- Archival content (Clients, Training, Admissions) doesn't fit the narrative voice and will need a format shift mid-page, creating an inconsistency the other territories don't have.
- Easy to drift into generic "personal-brand coach" visual territory if warmth isn't paired with genuinely confident typography and real specificity in the copy.

TERRITORY C

Civic Ledger

Durable, structural, public-record authority — an institution built to last.

01 CORE IDEA

The site borrows the visual logic of a public institution's record-keeping — a strong structural grid, navy as an architectural field rather than an accent, content organized like an official ledger or registry (admissions, decisions, positions treated as formal entries). The emotional register is permanence and reliability: this firm has been here, will keep being here, and keeps a careful record.

02 BRAND FIT

This is the weakest fit of the three for Russ's actual personality. It communicates durability and institutional trust well, and it can carry litigation strength through sheer structural confidence — but it has almost no natural room for "Call me Russ," empathy, or the sense of an ongoing personal adviser relationship, which the brief identifies as the firm's real differentiator and retention driver. Positioned as the site's *only* mode, it risks describing a durable institution rather than a person clients confide in. It's included here because its structural rigor is genuinely useful borrowed material, not because it should govern the whole site.

03 VISUAL VOCABULARY

A strict, visible grid — column lines, consistent baseline rhythm, entries numbered like registry items where that's literally true (bar admissions, court admissions, reported decisions). Full-bleed navy fields used as section dividers, with gold reserved for a single "seal"-like mark or rule, echoing an official insignia rather than a UI accent. Sharp corners, no shadows, no rounded cards — everything reads as printed and permanent rather than app-like. Section transitions are hard cuts, not fades. Motion is essentially absent, reinforcing solidity.

04 COLOR SYSTEM

☐ Navy — dominant field color #1E275E	☐ Gold — seal/insignia mark only #FDB613
☐ Paper (cool, near-white) #F2F2EE	☐ Navy-tinted rule #C7CADB
☐ Body text (cool graphite) #2B2E36	

Navy stops being a heading color and becomes architecture — full section backgrounds, not just text. White text on navy fields needs careful weight/size handling to hold contrast at body-text sizes; safest use is large-scale headings and short registry entries rather than long paragraphs reversed out of navy. Gold shrinks to its most restrained role of the three territories: a single mark, used the way an official seal or ribbon would be, not a general accent. Neutrals run cooler than the other two territories, reinforcing formality — this is the one direction where a cooler, more institutional grey genuinely fits the concept rather than reading as generic.

05 TYPOGRAPHY

The office-sign serif is used at large, confident scale for section headers set against navy fields — closer to how a courthouse or civic building would carve a name into stone than how a magazine sets a headline. Body copy pairs it with a slightly more geometric, neutral sans than the other territories (something like a grotesque in the Public Sans / IBM Plex Sans family) to reinforce the institutional register. Registry-style content (admissions, positions, reported decisions) gets tabular, aligned-figure treatment — literally formatted like entries in a ledger, with consistent columns for date/name/detail.

06 IMAGERY & ART DIRECTION

The lightest photography dependence of the three — this territory can run almost entirely on typography and structural graphic elements (the seal mark, ledger-style tables, architectural navy fields) with little or no photography at all. If imagery is used, documentary and regional — an actual Central Valley building, agricultural or civic texture specific to Fresno — never generic skyline or courthouse-column stock. Notably, this territory has the least natural place for a warm portrait of Russ, which is its core tension with the brand personality brief.

07 HOME-PAGE EXPRESSION

NAVY FIELD — full-bleed opening statement, large type, minimal copy, no photo

REGISTRY STRIP — admissions/ratings/years-practicing as a compact ledger row

PRACTICE GRID — six areas as a structured index, not cards

RECORD ENTRY — one formal "case on file" style proof entry

COUNSEL — brief, formal introduction to Russ — least personal of the three

FILE A CONSULTATION — form framed procedurally

PAYMENT — treated as another procedural utility, equally formal footing to

08 EXPERTISE-PAGE EXPRESSION

Practice areas presented as a formal index — closer to a table of contents than a marketing grid — with each area opening to a structured entry (scope, matter types, relevant record) rather than a conversational description. Efficient for a sophisticated buyer who wants to scan quickly and knows what they're looking for; less effective at building rapport for a first-time visitor who's still deciding whether they like this firm as people.

09 ABOUT-PAGE EXPRESSION

The strongest territory of the three for presenting archival material on its own terms — Positions, Admissions, and Clients genuinely want to look like ledger entries, and this territory gives them that treatment natively rather than forcing them into narrative prose. The cost is the biography: a strictly registry-style page has no comfortable place for a warm, human opening, and risks making even the "get to know Russ" moment feel like a formal filing.

10 CONTACT-PAGE EXPRESSION

Clear and procedurally trustworthy — good for expectation-setting stated as a formal, reliable process — but the least naturally "safe to confide in" of the three. Confidentiality language would need deliberate, careful warming here or it will read as a form disclaimer rather than reassurance.

11 PAYMENT-PAGE EXPRESSION

Actually a strong natural fit — a compact, procedural, secure-feeling utility page suits this

territory's formal register well, and institutional design language (clear hierarchy, security-forward copy) reads as trustworthy in a financial-transaction context specifically, even where it's a weaker fit for the rest of the site.

12 RESPONSIVE BEHAVIOR

Grid-driven systems collapse predictably and handle dense ledger content well at every width, including tall tablet. The main mobile risk is navy-field sections losing their architectural impact when compressed to a narrow viewport — full-bleed "monument" moments need a deliberate mobile-specific treatment rather than a naive scale-down, or they'll just look like plain colored boxes.

13 RISKS

- The single biggest risk: reads as a government agency or a large institutional firm, undercutting both "Call me Russ" informality and the small-firm personal-adviser positioning that's the actual differentiator.
- Least approachable of the three by a wide margin — could actively repel the "comfortable to confide in" audience even while impressing sophisticated institutional buyers.
- Civic/institutional aesthetics are having a broader design moment right now, which cuts both ways — distinctive today, but more likely than the other two territories to feel like it was chasing a trend if the trend passes.
- Structurally the hardest to soften later if it turns out clients respond better to warmth — retrofitting personality into a rigid ledger system is harder than adding structure to a warm one.

05 Qualification matrix

Scored 1–10 per territory. Deliberately not curved — several rows show a 4–5 point spread, because the territories genuinely trade off against each other rather than being three skins on one idea.

CRITERION	A RECORD	B OPEN DOOR	C CIVIC LEDGER	KEY TRADEOFF
Fit with Russ's personality	6	9	4	B is the only territory built directly from his voice; C mutes it almost entirely.
Approachability	5	9	4	A reads slightly clinical without warm copy; C reads institutional by design.
Trust & credibility	9	6	8	Evidence-forward structure (A) and institutional weight (C) both out-sign warmth alone.
Litigation strength (perceived)	8	4	7	B risks under-signaling formidability unless the record is given real visual weight somewhere.
Plain-language accessibility	7	9	6	B's whole premise is plain, first-person language.
Ability to handle dense content	9	5	8	B's narrative voice fights the site's most archival content (Clients, Training, Admissions).
Distinctiveness	7	7	6	All three beat the current generic template; none is a slam-dunk novelty.
Suitability for long-term clients	6	9	5	B is purpose-built for the ongoing-adviser relationship; C undersells it.
Responsive scalability	8	7	7	A's structured patterns collapse most predictably across widths.
Accessibility potential	8	7	7	Clear hierarchy and real structure (A) tend to produce better a11y outcome by default.
Maintainability	7	6	7	B needs the most ongoing editorial discipline to keep voice consistent as content grows.
Low dependence on new photography	8	3	7	B is unworkable without a real portrait session; A and C can largely proceed without one.
Risk of looking dated	8	6	7	Evidence-led editorial systems (A) age slower than either a personality-led or a trend-adjacent civic look.
Overall fit	8	6	5	A is the strongest single governing idea; B supplies what A is missing; contributes structure only.

06 Recommendation

01 Recommended territory: A — The Record, warmed by B

Lead with Territory A as the governing idea for structure, layout, and information hierarchy site-wide. Import Territory B's voice and portraiture specifically into the About-page biography opening, the Home-page introduction to Russ, and the Contact-page copy — the three places where "Call me Russ" needs to land in the reader's actual experience, not just the design brief.

02 Why this fits the real firm, not just the strongest mockup

The stated audiences — employers, health systems, nonprofits, and referring attorneys — are institutional and comparison-shopping buyers who evaluate counsel on evidence first and relationship second, even when the relationship is what keeps them for 20 years. A structure that leads with proof and lets warmth arrive through voice and portrait (rather than leading with warmth and hoping the proof lands later) matches how these specific buyers actually make a first decision. It's also the only territory that scores above a 7 on both "ability to handle dense content" and "trust and credibility" — the two criteria most directly tied to the audit's core finding that this firm's problem is presentation of depth, not a lack of it.

03 Elements worth borrowing from the other territories

From **Open Door (B)**: the first-person, direct-address voice for connective copy; at least one strong environmental portrait of Russ as a real structural anchor, not a small circular headshot; the Contact-page framing device of Russ personally reassuring a nervous first-time caller. From **Civic Ledger (C)**: the tabular, registry-style treatment for genuinely archival content — Positions, Admissions, reported decisions — which is a stronger native fit for that specific content than either A's or B's default treatment; and its instinct to treat Payment as a formal, procedural utility, which fits that page's actual job regardless of which territory governs the rest of the site.

04

WHAT SHOULD EXPLICITLY NOT BE COMBINED

Do not adopt Civic Ledger's full-bleed navy institutional register as a site-wide mode alongside Open Door's conversational first-person voice — the two pull in opposite emotional directions (monument vs. letter) and combining them wholesale would produce a site that feels inconsistent rather than layered. Civic Ledger's contribution should stay scoped to specific archival content patterns and the Payment page, not become a competing visual identity running in parallel with the governing Territory A structure.

05 Biggest unresolved questions

(1) The office-sign typeface is a working hypothesis, not a confirmed answer — this needs to close before any type system is locked. (2) Whether there's real budget and appetite for a commissioned photography session with Russ — the recommended hybrid's warmth depends on at least one strong portrait existing. (3) How much conversational looseness Russ actually wants in written copy versus a more disciplined "counsel" register — this needs to come from him directly, not be inferred. (4) Whether the referring-attorney audience deserves its own explicit pathway (a labeled section or page) or should stay folded into About's admissions/appellate record as currently planned. (5) Final legal review and sign-off on confidentiality and expectation-setting language before any of it ships.

06 What input would most improve the next phase

A short recorded conversation or interview with Russ — even 15–20 minutes of him talking naturally about a case, a long-term client relationship, or how he explains his own approach — would do more to calibrate the actual voice than any amount of further design speculation. Confirmation (or correction) of the typeface hypothesis from your sister. A decision on photography budget/timeline. And a shortlist from Russ of 3–5 client relationships he'd be comfortable naming or featuring as proof points, since several of the strongest moves in Territory A depend on being able to cite real, specific evidence rather than categories.

07 Next recommended deliverable

Two things, in order: first, a short written voice-and-tone guide (a page, not a document) that turns whatever comes out of the Russ conversation into concrete word-choice guidance — this is cheap to produce and de-risks everything downstream. Second, a single fully-worked page concept — About is the highest-value candidate, since it's where the audit found the most acute presentation problem and where this recommendation's hybrid approach (Territory A structure, Territory B voice, Territory C's registry treatment for archival sections) needs to be pressure-tested together in one place before committing to a full component system across all five routes.

07 Provisional content architecture

Section-level outlines, not copy and not an implementation plan. Written to fit Territory A as governing structure, warmed per the recommendation above.

Home

/

1. **Opening statement** — who the firm serves, stated plainly, with one hard proof number

2. **Credential strip** — 3–4 real marks, small and factual

3. **Firm introduction** — one tight paragraph in Russ's voice

4. **Practice map** — six areas, each with a differentiator line, linking to Expertise

5. **Record preview** — 2–3 proof points pulled from About, linking to the full record

6. **Meet Russ** — portrait + short human intro, linking to full biography

7. **Consultation** — existing form, framed with one expectation-setting sentence

8. **Utility footer** — Payment access as a calm secondary action

PRIMARY QUESTION

Is this a firm that handles people like me, and can I trust them?

MUST BE VISIBLE IMMEDIATELY

Who the firm serves, one proof number, the consultation path.

CROSS-LINKS

Practice map → Expertise; record preview + Meet Russ → About; footer → Payment.

PRIMARY ACTION

Start a consultation; secondary: explore a specific practice area.

PROGRESSIVELY DISCLOSED

Full practice detail and full record stay one click away, not on-page.

CONTENT PATTERN

Short declarative sections, no long-form prose beyond the firm-intro paragraph.

Expertise

/expertise

1. **Framing line** — how to use this page (replaces generic "click a topic" instruction)

2. **Six practice sections** — plain description + representative matter types + one proof point each

3. **Cross-link block per section** — direct link into the relevant About record entry

4. **Not sure which fits?** — a plain, low-friction link straight to Contact

https://claude.ai/code/artifact/ab1f9592-678a-4507-95c9-01d571af9ba8?via=auto_preview

20/20